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Tip of the Day

The Relative vs. Absolute Trick

When to use this:

When a question compares two degrees of the same word

(e.g. "strong" vs "stronger", "efficient" vs "most efficient")

Relative

Good compared to something else.

Words ending in -er / -est or with more / most

"stronger" "most efficient"

Absolute

Good on its own, no comparison.

The base form of the word, with nothing to compare to

"strong" "efficient"

Answer template:

"[X] is only [quality] in relative terms, compared to [Y], but not [quality] in absolute terms."

From the mark schemes:

Explain why the writer uses the phrase 'most efficient' rather than the word 'efficient' in the expression 'To devise the most efficient route I could'. (line 37)

Award 1 mark for any of the following:

- the best / safest / simplest / quickest
- none (of the potential routes) are efficient / this is the least-worst option / knew it wasn't going to be efficient

EXAMPLE ANSWER:

"The route was not good on its own, but only the best in comparison to others."

Explain why the writer uses the word 'stronger' rather than 'strong' in the expression 'a stronger branch' (line 49).

Award one mark for any of the following:

- shows Mo is still not safe even after landing / branch he landed on was weak and likely to break

OR

- suggests that none of the branches are safe or strong – all have the potential to break; can make his position slightly safer but not safe

OR

- the branch is comparatively stronger / stronger in relative terms, but not strong (in absolute terms)

EXAMPLE ANSWER:

"The branch was only stronger in relative terms, not in absolute terms."

NOTE: THE RELATIVE FORM IS THE WORSE OPTION. BASE WORD IS ALWAYS BETTER.

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